

A Mostly Harmless Introduction to Claude Code, Codex and Friends

For Empirical Researchers

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September 3, 2026

Welcome

- Workshops for Ukraine
- Who this talk is for: empirical researchers, not software engineers
- What we will and will not cover

Agenda

- Why AI coding assistants matter for research workflows
- Meet the tools: Claude Code, Codex, and friends
- Terminal-based agents vs. chat-based assistants
- A live demo on a real research task
- Practical tips, pitfalls, and where to go from here

Why This Matters for Empirical Research

- Research code is mostly glue: cleaning data, wrangling, plotting, writing
- Agentic coding tools can operate directly on your project files
- Faster iteration on data pipelines, replication code, and slide decks like this one

Meet the Tools

Claude Code

- Anthropic's agentic CLI coding tool
- Reads and edits files, runs shell commands, uses MCP servers

Codex

- OpenAI's agentic coding tool
- Similar workflow, different ecosystem and defaults

Friends

- Other agentic assistants worth knowing about

Terminal Agents vs. Chat Assistants

- Chat assistants: copy-paste in and out of a browser
- Terminal agents: operate on your actual project, run code, iterate on errors
- Implications for reproducibility and version control

Live Demo

- A real empirical research task, done live
- What to watch for: prompting, verification, undoing mistakes

Practical Tips for Researchers

- Treat the agent like a capable but literal-minded research assistant
- Always verify output against the data and the code, not just the prose
- Version control everything; commit before letting an agent make large changes

Pitfalls

- Hallucinated results and citations
- Silent errors in statistical code
- Overtrusting output without inspecting intermediate steps

Resources and Where to Go Next

- Documentation links
- Community and support channels
- Questions

Thank You

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